

The King, the Gold and the Textbook Mystery

Mansa Musa, the hajj of 1324, and how historians know what they know

GRADE 8 HISTORY · WHAT'S INSIDE

- One short reading at three reading levels, with the same facts in each
- A sorting activity: well supported, debated, or can't be known?
- A two-part quiz with a short written answer, plus answer key and rubric
- Teacher notes, and pages showing how the pack was checked

Drafted with AI and checked against the sources listed on the last page. Please read it through before using it with students.

Teacher notes

The big question: Was Mansa Musa really "the richest person who ever lived", and how do historians decide what to believe?

Students will

- describe Mansa Musa's hajj of 1324 and what it shows about the Mali Empire
- explain why some claims about the past are well supported, some are debated, and some cannot be known
- ask of any source: who said this, when, and how could they know?

Three readings, same facts

Level	Words	Flesch-Kincaid grade	Best for
Support	288	4.7	Students who need extra language support, or a quicker read
Core	365	8.3	Most of the class
Extension	407	10.5	Students ready for more complex sentences and ideas

Grades were measured with the Flesch-Kincaid formula. They are a guide, not a promise: always check against your own students.

Suggested lesson (about 50 minutes)

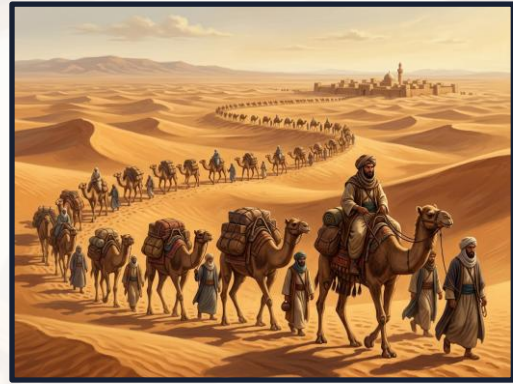
5 min	Hook: show of hands, "Who was the richest person who ever lived?" Take answers without comment.
15 min	Students read at their level and underline one claim they find surprising.
15 min	Sorting activity in pairs: well supported, debated, or can't be known? Students give evidence for each choice.
10 min	Quiz, or use the short written answer as an exit ticket.
5 min	Return to the hook. Has anyone changed their mind, and why?

The same quiz works with all three readings. The answer key and rubric come after the quiz, and the last two pages show how the facts were checked. This pack is not tied to any one curriculum, so adapt the objectives to your own standards.



Name: _____ Date: _____

A King on a Long Journey



Mansa Musa was the king of Mali, a large empire in West Africa. He ruled for about 25 years in the early 1300s. At that time, West Africa was a major source of gold. People in North Africa, the Middle East and Europe all wanted it.

Mansa Musa was a Muslim. In 1324, he left Mali to make the hajj. The hajj is a journey to the holy city of Mecca. Muslims who are able to are expected to make it. Musa's journey was very long. He crossed the Sahara Desert with an enormous group of travellers and a great deal of gold.

In July 1324, Musa reached Cairo, the capital of Egypt. He met the ruler of Egypt, the sultan. Later writers said that Musa gave away so much gold in Cairo that its value fell. Some modern historians are not sure how big that effect really was.

Musa then went home to Mali. Reports say he brought scholars home with him. During his reign, Mali took control of Timbuktu, a city that later became famous for trade and learning.

How do we know about Musa? Most of what we know comes from Arabic writers who wrote after his journey. One of them was al-Umari. He did not meet Musa. He asked people in Cairo who had met him. A map made in Europe in 1375, the Catalan Atlas, also shows a king of Mali holding a gold nugget.

On the internet, you may read that Musa was worth 400 billion dollars. That number comes from a website in 2012, not from a medieval source. Historians say nobody can really work it out. A good historian asks three questions: Who said this? When? How could they know?

KEY WORDS

hajj: the pilgrimage to Mecca that Muslims who are able to are expected to make. **entourage:** the group of people who travel with an important person. **caravan:** a group of travellers crossing a desert together. **second-hand:** told to the writer by other people, not seen by the writer.

Name: _____ Date: _____

The King Who Crossed the Sahara



In 1324, the ruler of the Mali Empire set out on a journey that people would still be talking about hundreds of years later. Mansa Musa, who ruled for about 25 years in the early 1300s, was a devout Muslim, and he was making the hajj, the pilgrimage to Mecca that Muslims are expected to make at least once if they are able.

Musa ruled one of the largest states in West Africa. His empire controlled lands and trade routes that supplied a large share of the gold wanted by North Africa, the Middle East and Europe. During his reign, Mali also took control of the cities of Gao and Timbuktu. When he left for Mecca, he travelled with an enormous entourage and a vast supply of gold.

In July 1324, the caravan reached Cairo, the capital of the Mamluk Sultanate. Musa met the Mamluk sultan, al-Nasir Muhammad, and his lavish gift-giving made a deep impression. Later writers claimed that he gave away so much gold that its value in Cairo fell and took years to recover. Some modern historians, however, question how big or how unusual that effect really was.

After the pilgrimage, Musa returned to Mali, and sources say he brought scholars home with him. Timbuktu later became famous across the Muslim world as a centre of trade and learning, and news of Mali's wealth travelled north. A European map from 1375, the Catalan Atlas, shows a Mali ruler seated on a throne and holding a gold nugget.

Historians have to be careful with this story, because much of it comes from writers who were not in Mali. Most of what we know comes from Arabic writers who wrote after the pilgrimage. One of them, al-Umari, learned about Musa from officials in Cairo who had met him, which makes his account second-hand. It is useful evidence, but not perfect evidence.

The internet adds a further problem. You may read that Musa was worth 400 billion dollars. That figure comes from a celebrity net-worth website in 2012, and economic historians say his wealth cannot be reduced to a number. A good historian asks of every claim: Who said this? When? How could they know?

KEY WORDS

hajj: the pilgrimage to Mecca that Muslims who are able to are expected to make. **entourage:** the group of people who travel with an important person. **caravan:** a group of travellers crossing a desert together. **second-hand:** told to the writer by other people, not seen by the writer.

READING · EXTENSION

Name: _____ Date: _____

Gold, Pilgrimage and the Problem of Sources



When Mansa Musa left Mali for Mecca in 1324, he already ruled one of the largest states in West Africa. He ruled for about 25 years in the early 1300s, and during his reign Mali took control of the important trading cities of Gao and Timbuktu. West Africa was a major source of the gold that circulated around the Mediterranean world, and Musa's pilgrimage turned that wealth into a public display: he travelled with an enormous entourage and a vast supply of gold.

His stay in Cairo in July 1324 is the best-known episode of the journey. He met the Mamluk sultan, al-Nasir Muhammad, and his generosity became famous. Al-Umari, writing in the late 1330s from what people in Cairo told him, said that gold stayed cheap there for about twelve years, and one modern popular account adds a fall of about a fifth against silver. A scholarly study of the surviving exchange-rate evidence, however, has questioned whether Musa's visit was the unique cause of the fall in gold prices that textbooks describe. It is a good example of an anecdote that is repeated so often it begins to feel like settled fact.

The evidence deserves attention in its own right. Much of what we know about Musa comes from Arabic writers who wrote after the pilgrimage. The historian al-Umari, for instance, gathered information from an official in Cairo who had met Musa, so his account is second-hand. Many accounts say that Musa brought scholars back to Mali, but details differ between sources, and some claims are repeated so widely that their origins are hard to trace.

Outsiders shaped Musa's image as well. The Catalan Atlas of 1375, made in Europe for readers who had never seen Mali, shows a Mali ruler, usually identified as Musa, holding a gold nugget, and its caption calls him the richest and most noble king in the land. The map tells us what some Europeans believed about Mali's wealth, which is not the same as telling us what Mali was like.

Today's internet adds another layer. In 2012, a celebrity net-worth website estimated Musa's fortune at 400 billion dollars, and the figure spread widely. Economic historians, however, say that his wealth cannot be reduced to a single number: the evidence is thin, and a medieval king's wealth cannot be compared directly with a modern billionaire's. A good historian asks of every claim: Who said this? When? And how could they know?

KEY WORDS

hajj: the pilgrimage to Mecca that Muslims who are able to are expected to make. **entourage:** the group of people who travel with an important person. **caravan:** a group of travellers crossing a desert together. **second-hand:** told to the writer by other people, not seen by the writer.

Well supported, debated, or can't be known?

Name: _____ Date: _____

Historians do not treat every claim the same way. Read each claim about Mansa Musa. Tick one box, then write the evidence that helped you decide.

Well supported: several good sources agree, or we can look at the evidence ourselves.

Debated: sources or historians disagree.

Can't be known: the evidence is too thin, or the claim cannot be measured.



#	Claim	Well supported	Debated	Can't be known	My evidence
1	Musa's gold made the price of gold in Cairo fall for twelve years.	☐	☐	☐	
2	Musa made the hajj to Mecca in 1324.	☐	☐	☐	
3	Musa was the richest person who ever lived, worth 400 billion dollars.	☐	☐	☐	
4	Al-Umari learned about Musa from officials in Cairo who had met him.	☐	☐	☐	
5	Exactly 60,000 people travelled with Musa.	☐	☐	☐	
6	The Catalan Atlas of 1375 shows a Mali ruler holding gold.	☐	☐	☐	
7	Musa ruled Mali from 1312 to 1337.	☐	☐	☐	
8	Musa reached Cairo in July 1324 and met the Mamluk sultan, al-Nasir Muhammad.	☐	☐	☐	

Quiz (part 1 of 2)

Name: _____ Date: _____

1. Which empire did Mansa Musa rule?

- A. The Mamluk Sultanate
- B. The Songhai Empire
- C. The Mali Empire
- D. The Ghana Empire

2. Why did Musa travel to Mecca in 1324?

- A. To trade for salt
- B. To make the hajj, the Muslim pilgrimage
- C. To conquer Cairo
- D. To meet European merchants

3. In which city did Musa meet the Mamluk sultan al-Nasir Muhammad?

- A. Timbuktu
- B. Mecca
- C. Gao
- D. Cairo

4. What do some modern historians say about the story that Musa's gold crashed the price of gold in Cairo?

- A. It has been proved exactly by exchange-rate records
- B. It was invented in the twentieth century
- C. They question how big or how unusual the effect really was
- D. It happened in Timbuktu, not Cairo

Circle one answer for each question.

Quiz (part 2 of 2)

Name: _____ Date: _____

5. Why is al-Umari's account called second-hand?

- A. He copied it from a map
- B. He learned about Musa from officials in Cairo who had met him
- C. He wrote it centuries before Musa lived
- D. He was one of Musa's servants on the journey

6. What does the Catalan Atlas of 1375 mainly tell us?

- A. Exactly how much gold Mali produced
- B. The route of Musa's pilgrimage
- C. Where the gold mines of Mali were
- D. What some Europeans believed about Mali's wealth

7. Where does the figure of 400 billion dollars for Musa's wealth come from?

- A. Al-Umari's account
- B. The British Museum
- C. A celebrity net-worth website in 2012
- D. A Mamluk court record

8. Which question should a good historian ask about a claim?

- A. How many people have shared it online?
- B. Who said this, when, and how could they know?
- C. Does it sound impressive?
- D. Is it in a textbook?

9. A website says that Mansa Musa was worth 400 billion dollars. In three or four sentences, explain why a historian would treat this claim with caution. Use at least one idea from the reading.

Answer key and rubric

Quiz, questions 1 to 8

1 C	2 B	3 D	4 C	5 B	6 D	7 C	8 B
-----	-----	-----	-----	-----	-----	-----	-----

Sorting activity

#	Category	Why
1	Debated	Al-Umari, writing in the late 1330s, repeated what people in Cairo told him: gold stayed cheap for about twelve years. A scholarly study questions whether Musa's visit was the unique cause, and how big the effect was.
2	Well supported	Sources agree on this, including the reference works used for this pack.
3	Can't be known	The figure came from a celebrity net-worth website in 2012. Economic historians say his wealth cannot be reduced to a number.
4	Well supported	Al-Umari visited Cairo a few years after the hajj and wrote down what people there, including an emir who had met Musa, told him.
5	Can't be known	Reports of the caravan's size are second-hand ('it was said that...') and are repeated online without a clear origin.
6	Well supported	We can look at the map itself. Abraham Cresques of Mallorca drew it about fifty years after the hajj, so it shows what Europeans believed.
7	Debated	Britannica gives 1307 to 1332. Other references give 1312 to 1337.
8	Well supported	Reference works agree on the date and on the meeting.

Question 9: 4 points, 1 for each criterion

Origin of the claim	Says where the figure comes from (a 2012 celebrity net-worth website, not a medieval source).
Why it is doubtful	Explains why the number cannot be trusted (the evidence is thin, or a medieval king's wealth cannot be compared directly with a modern fortune).
Use of the reading	Uses a specific idea or fact from the reading.
Clear writing	Three or four clear sentences that stay on the question.

How this pack was checked

AI wrote the first drafts. The key factual claims were then checked against the sources listed on the next page, and anything the sources did not support was softened or left out. This is the same routine taught in the AI for Teachers program.

Confirmed by more than one source

- That Musa made the hajj in 1324 (Britannica, World History Encyclopedia, Wikipedia).
- That he reached Cairo in July 1324 and met the Mamluk sultan al-Nasir Muhammad (World History Encyclopedia, Wikipedia, and al-Umari's own account).
- That Mali took control of Gao and Timbuktu in his reign (Britannica, World History Encyclopedia, Wikipedia).
- That he brought scholars home from the hajj (Britannica, World History Encyclopedia).
- That al-Umari wrote down what people in Cairo told him (Boston University's primary-source page, citing Levitzion and Hopkins, and Wikipedia).
- That the Catalan Atlas of 1375 shows a Mali ruler holding a gold nugget (World History Encyclopedia, Wikimedia Commons).

What changed during checking

Reign dates	Britannica gives 1307 to 1332. World History Encyclopedia gives 1312 to 1337. Both are about 25 years, so the pack says he ruled for about 25 years in the early 1300s, and uses the dates as a debated claim.
The gold crash	Popular pages state as fact that Musa crashed the price of gold in Cairo. The twelve-year figure goes back to al-Umari, who repeated what people in Cairo told him. A scholarly study questions how unique and how large the effect was, so the pack presents it as reported and debated.
The 400 billion dollar figure	Many websites state this as fact. The BBC traces it to a celebrity net-worth website in 2012 and says economic historians agree it cannot be calculated. One web page credited 2023 Oxford research, which could not be verified, so that was left out. The figure appears only as a claim for students to test.
Birth year	Some sources give 1280. Another reference says the date of birth is unknown. The pack gives no birth year.
Caravan size	Reports of the caravan's size are second-hand ('it was said that...') and are repeated online with no clear origin, so the pack gives no number.
Reading levels	Measured with the Flesch-Kincaid formula, not guessed. See the Teacher Notes page.

What to check yourself

- Statements marked 'later writers claimed' rest on sources written after the hajj.
- The scholarly study of the Cairo gold market was read in summary and excerpt only. Read the full article before quoting it.
- Sources differ on who the scholars were (Britannica says Egyptian scholars; other accounts mention architects). The pack keeps to 'scholars'.

Sources

- Encyclopaedia Britannica, 'Mali' and 'Musa' (Britannica Kids)
- World History Encyclopedia, 'Mansa Musa I' (worldhistory.org)
- Boston University African Studies, 'Kingdom of Mali: Primary Source Documents', al-Umari, cited from Levitzion and Hopkins, Corpus of Early Arabic Sources for West African History (Cambridge University Press, 1981)
- BBC News, 'Is Mansa Musa the richest man who ever lived?' (2019)
- Wikipedia, 'Mansa Musa', used as a starting point and cross-checked, not as a final authority
- 'Mansa Musa's Gold in Mamluk Cairo: A Reappraisal of a World Civilizations Anecdote' (scholarly article, read in summary)
- Catalan Atlas, 1375, Abraham Cresques of Mallorca (Bibliothèque nationale de France, Espagnol 30)

Want to make materials like this for your own classes?

AI for Teachers is ten one-hour, one-to-one sessions built around your own lessons, with a full session on quality assurance. Free 30-minute call to start.

teachers.executeai.it.com

Kenny Rooney · kennyjrooney@gmail.com